NOVELISTIC SCREENPLAY

POKÉMON NOCTURNE

EPISODE 10

The Living Tradition

Author
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Working compilation

Status · draft · pass 1/3 recorded · EN-GB apparatus

Format	Novelistic screenplay · EN anchors
Target duration	To be set — corpus ≈ 75 min read aloud
Scenes	14
Version	2026-09-24 · EN-GB dossier after P1

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Episode sheet

Series Pokémon Nocturne
Episode 10 — The Living Tradition
Author Adelbert Vervloet

Logline

Glare from an Arbok on deposit. Clair sees a mist. At the monastery: longevity is not a gift. Sayo: to restore a life is no simpler than to bring back the dead. Red rises without a miracle. Silver at the gate. The League holds. Gold/Richter leaves for Kanto.

Place in the arc

Due: Dex; the softening; Ho-Oh / Lugia; Silver.
Paid: 8th badge under reserve; tradition = renewal; the Red task accepted.
Open: Kanto; Red still on Mt. Silver; the white spectre.

Characters — this episode only

Name	Function here
Gold/Richter · Clair	Gym 8; monastery; Clair spelling only
Chris/Maria	Elm; Ecruteak; death as repetition
Clan chief	Longevity; living tradition
Sayo / Morty / Eusine	Dance; dignified life; Kanto The Kimono Girl who crossed paths with the protagonist in Ice Path.
Red / Silver	Mt. Silver; Route 22 / 26
Lance (Champion) + Elite Four	White hall — ≠ Team Rocket executive
Elm / Karin / Will / Koga / Bruno	Caustic concession; League close

Places (EN anchors)

Blackthorn Gym · Dragon's Den (cave, monastery) · Ecruteak (theatre, dance) · Elm's laboratory · Mt. Silver · Route 26 / Reception Gate · League.

Technical notes — outside the scenes

Heading	Note
Arbok	On deposit: joint research (the Professors). Partial training by Gold/Richter. Not full possession. An anchor in the gym (research Ball); the status remains here.
Clair	Single spelling. Not Claire.
Two Lances	The executive's Golbat ランス ≠ Champion ワタル (final hall).
Route 22 / 26	Title: Giovanni's abandonment (Kanto, Route 22). Scene location: Route 26, Reception Gate. Keep both if both are intended.

Heavenly Father (flight to the Den)	Reference: Maria Renard flies toward the abbey, EP04 S02 of Castlevania: Nocturne.
P1 gels	chief (not leader / boss / chef). imprecation (Pokédex) ≠ curse (Kanto, Sayo). polar, not polarising. repetition, not rehearsal. Pokémon pronouns: it/its (Kingdra: to be frozen once).

Screen durations (excluding titles)

Longevity 7 min 30–8. Trust 1 min 20–40. Obligation 2 min 10–3 min 10. Glances 1 min–1 min 15. Revision of death 4 min 30–5 min 30. Route 22 ≈ 3 min 40–4 min 10. Spirituality 5 min 50–6 min 20.

BGM index — pieces (Nocturne OST)

Scene	Piece	Range
Unprecedented Apathy	What Power Art Thou	entry
Heavenly Father / monastery	Heavenly Father	00:00– · 00:25 · 00:31–01:04 · 00:51–01:04 · 01:04–01:51
The Obligation of the 8th Gym	Vampire Messiah	00:46–01:17
The Stature of the Badges	A Third Soul	00:00–01:48
Innocent and Accusing Glances	Powerful Predatory Deadly	02:22–end · 02:35– · 02:58– · 03:12– · 03:24–
Restoring a Dignified Life…	Being Dracula's Son	entry
Restoring a Dignified Life…	Dido's Lament	00:32–end · external
Restoring a Dignified Life…	Source of Your Fury	entry
Ordinary Mercy	Making Monsters	00:00–00:44
Ordinary Mercy	Powerful Predatory Deadly	00:44–01:24
The End of Route 22	Wouldn't Understand	entry
Route 22 / League	My Sister	00:00–00:30
Spirituality and the Journey	Divine Bloodlines Reprise	entry

BGM index — traces

Address only.

Scene	BGM
Longevity Is Not an Absolute Asset	EP06 S02 12:40–15:30
The Obligation of the 8th Gym	EP01 S02 10:00–10:21
The Stature of the Badges	EP07 S01 05:36–08:06
The Stature of the Badges	EP03 S01 15:36–16:22
The Loss of Purpose	EP05 S02 01:20–02:48
The Caustic Concession in the Past	EP03 S01 16:54–17:29
The Caustic Concession in the Past	EP01 S01 14:37–16:34
The Caustic Concession in the Past	EP04 S02 02:30–03:45 (00:29–end)
The Revision of Death	EP07 S01 17:36–19:00

The Revision of Death	EP01 S02 12:00–13:54
The End of Route 22	EP01 S02 04:30–05:40

Order of scenes

1. Unprecedented Apathy
2. Heavenly Father (flight to the Den)
3. Longevity Is Not an Absolute Asset
4. Trust in the Intelligence of the Young
5. The Obligation of the 8th Gym
6. The Stature of the Badges
7. The Loss of Purpose
8. The Caustic Concession in the Past
9. Innocent and Accusing Glances
10. The Revision of Death
11. Restoring a Dignified Life and Reliving the Dead
12. Ordinary Mercy
13. The End of Route 22
14. Spirituality and the Journey

The scenes are inserted here. The close follows the body.

Scene – Unprecedented apathy

8th Gym, where the battle with Clair is about to unfold.

BGM: 'What Power Art Thou' (Nocturne version) EP04S02 09:47-12:17

The battle seemed to go on forever. Kingdra continued to move through the water, graceful, almost defiant, as if nothing could truly harm it.

Gold/Richter had not uttered a word for some time. He merely watched. Simply.

Then, very quietly, almost to himself, he murmured something inaudible.

Arbok drew itself up.

That was all. Glare.

Kingdra stopped dead in its tracks.

It did not move. Its eyes remained wide open, fixed on the Arbok. No twitching, no spasms. Just a strange stillness, as if something inside it had frozen from within. It seemed… absorbed. As if the Arbok's gaze were forcing her to stay there, to watch, unable to look away.

Clair felt her breath catch.

Her gaze drifted involuntarily behind Gold/Richter.

And she saw—or thought she saw—a dark, blurred shape that seemed to be floating just behind his shoulders. Not quite a silhouette. More like a cold, dense mist that had no business being in this room. As if something ancient and alien had crept up behind him without him realising it.

Gold/Richter was barely moving. His face was calm. Too calm. His gaze was fixed on Kingdra, but he no longer seemed to be really seeing her. As if he were looking right through her, towards something else. Or as if something were passing right through him.

Clair felt a chill creeping up the nape of her neck, slow and viscous.

The sound in the room seemed to grow heavier. A low, reluctant, almost defiant note rose into the air, as if something ancient were reluctantly awakening.

Gold/Richter blinked. Once. Twice. He ran a hand over his face, as if to shake off a sudden wave of tiredness. When he looked up again, his gaze had returned to near normal — tired, distant, but present.

The Arbok slowly lowered its head.

Kingdra trembled violently, as if it had just been released from an invisible pressure. It lurched backwards, disoriented.

Clair said nothing.

She kept her eyes fixed on the empty space behind Gold/Richter.

… As if those eyes… were swallowing everything.

Gold/Richter did not seem to have noticed.

End of scene

Scene – Heavenly Father

Cave, Dragon's Den

BGM 'Heavenly Father' 00:00–

The air inside the cave was cooler, heavy with moisture. At the water's edge, Dratini glided between the smooth rocks. A few Magikarp rose to the surface, then dived back down silently. The eddies swirled slowly, seemingly steady, but already denser than they ought to have been.

Gold/Richter stood upon a mound of stone, not far from the entrance. Standing slightly back, Ace Trainer Kobe and Ace Trainer Piper waited, with Dragonair standing between them. Their stillness conveyed nothing specific. Neither defiance, nor goodwill, nor mere curiosity. Only intense focus.

Gold/Richter opened his eyes without haste. The two tails of his tailcoat fluttered slightly in the breeze, with natural suppleness. He took a step forward, assessed the situation, and threw the Ball with a crisp, economical motion.

BGM 'Heavenly Father' 00:25–

Kobe and Piper exchanged a brief glance. Dragonair gave a slight nod.

BGM 'Heavenly Father' 00:31–01:04

Fearow's silhouette materialised. Even before the bird had fully spread its wings, Gold/Richter had already grasped its talons. The movement was precise and seamless. Take-off followed immediately, fluidly. No visible effort. No struggle against the wind.

They soared upwards.

Below them, the water changed. The eddies quickened, growing tighter and more abrupt. Cross-currents formed between the rocks, sharp as scythe blades. Some stones, though motionless, seemed to have drawn closer.

A closer shot of Fearow's wing: the feathers taut, steady, almost rigid under the pressure of the air. Then a shot of the talons: Gold/Richter's grip, firm, without excessive tension.

Another shot, from a lower angle. The cross-currents swept right beneath them, sharp and swift, as if searching for the slightest flaw. The water posed no threat yet. It simply existed with an intensity that left no room for error.

Gold/Richter's gaze. Determined, unshakeable, already fixed ahead. No visible hesitation. Only absolute focus on the flight path.

Below, the eddies intensified still further. More impetuous. More sucking. Gusts of black water swirled as if trying to absorb whatever was passing overhead. The threat was not spectacular. It was close. So close as to seem to be directed at the observer as well.

Fearow moved straight ahead, steady. Gold/Richter clung on without unnecessary tension, his body aligned. The movement retained a sense of certainty, almost peaceful, like a trajectory already known.

They covered the final stretch.

BGM 'Heavenly Father' 00:51–01:04

The landing took place near Dragon's Den monastery. Gold/Richter released his grip at exactly the right moment, touched the ground without losing his balance, and stood up straight. The tails of his tailcoat and the rest of his outfit fell back into place of their own accord, without him paying them any mind.

He opened his eyes. His expression was neutral. He wasn't looking for anything from Kobe or Piper. He wasn't expecting any particular reaction. Already focused on what lay ahead, he was simply assessing what remained for him to prepare.

End of scene

Scene – Longevity Is Not an Absolute Asset

Monastery, Dragon's Den

BGM 'Heavenly Father' 01:04–01:51

The air near the monastery was drier than at the entrance to the cave. Low-hanging lamps cast a steady yellow light upon the dark wooden walls. The scent of green tea mingled with that of light incense.

The chief sat in the seiza position, Clair's letter open before him. Gold/Richter, facing him, adopted the same posture. The cup of tea to his right remained almost full. He had no appetite.

The chief read through the lines without haste. At a particular paragraph, a very faint, almost imperceptible smile appeared at the corner of his lips. Neither outright mockery nor frank approval. Just something enigmatic that made Gold/Richter's shoulders tense slightly.

The chief laid the letter down beside him, took a sip of tea, then spoke in an even voice.

'My augury for success in the first trial. The seal was intact. You neither opened nor intercepted it. Welldone.'

The compliment did little to lighten the atmosphere.

Gold/Richter asked cautiously:

"Am I… an exception? Someone whom Clair refuses to award the badge?"

"No. You're not the first. Clair has asked me to check certain successful candidates. As a precaution."

He picked up the letter again for a moment, glancing at it askance.

"In this correspondence, she's tried to remain objective. But she hasn't always held back what she really thinks. That's… extremely rare for her."

Gold/Richter lowered his gaze slightly.

“If I’m not trustworthy, don’t feel obliged. I’m not keen on badges. Nor on the title of Champion.”

His tone was melancholic, without any pretence. The chief watched him for a moment longer.

“That’s my interpretation. Not yet my opinion.”

He put the letter down.

“The way you won the battle was daring. Clair is strong for her age. Many challengers find themselves outmatched and call it strategy. The problem isn’t the strategy itself. It’s the orientation. She writes almost as if you’d abused the Pokémon. It’s… interesting.”

Gold/Richter did not take the remark as an accusation. He simply replied:

“Strong Pokémon. Weak Pokémon. That is only the selfish perception of people. Truly skilled trainers should try to win with their favorites.”

The leader raised his eyebrows slightly. The remark, coming from such a young boy, had taken him by surprise.

Gold/Richter continued, his voice firmer, almost stern:

“It’s not the same as the version the person who coined it originally meant. But it still holds true. Battling with those you’ve chosen… requires more courage. More preparation. More adaptability. Even more intelligence. Especially when you’re at a disadvantage. And when you refuse to win by any means necessary. Otherwise, those words are nothing more than an excuse.”

The leader nodded slowly.

“So strategy is merely a means to an end. And it all depends on the person using it.”

“Yes. I’ve seen too many cases where everything is optimised: equipment, abilities, set-ups. A level of sophistication… that ultimately makes the Pokémon less self-reliant. More dependent. Almost like puppets. I’m trying to avoid that.”

The leader did not reply straight away; his interest had clearly grown.

“Very well. When facing Clair… how do you choose your Pokémon? Based on the individual? On innate talent?”

Gold/Richter paused to consider, then replied earnestly.

“If you mean picking individuals for their gifts… I do not prioritise that.”

“Why?”

“Because Pokémon are almost as intelligent as we are. If we place too much emphasis on their natural gifts, they risk becoming corrupted. Just like humans. Privileges from birth… are often the start of corruption. I believe that natural talent matters. But diligence, determination, learning, trust, and intimacy… are worth more. So I focus instead on discipline. Perseverance. Scholarship.”

The chief was now watching him intently.

“What drives you to take this approach?”

Gold/Richter searched for his words. Speaking came with difficulty.

“In combat, they often sense things sooner than we do. If they aren’t disciplined… even an excellent trainer can no longer really bring out the best in them. I refine them when necessary. But I let them keep their instinct. I merely humanise it. I trust in their nature. It’s… a way of respecting them. And of maintaining harmony.”

He paused, feeling uncomfortable at having spoken for so long.

“If my words seem clumsy… I’m not very familiar with your village or your culture. I apologise.”

The chief shook his head slightly.

‘Do not worry. We are part of Johto. Yet we often feel like outsiders here. The geographical distance has a lot to do with it. Still, we feel at home here too.’

He took another sip of tea, then continued, more slowly.

“Many Trainers love the Dragon type for its power. For its potential. That’s not our way.”

BGM: ‘EP06 S02 12:40–15:30’

Gold/Richter looked up, surprised.

‘Dragons are not merely powerful creatures,’ continued the chieftain. ‘They are rare. Yet, whilst they are still developing, they are usually vulnerable.

To reach their full potential, they need shelter. The tolerance of more fleeting, more ordinary beings. Without that, strength does not come. It is bestowed.

They are long-lived. Long enough to experience frustrations that mortals struggle to imagine. Longevity is not a gift given freely. It demands a price.

We admire their strength. We often forget what it costs. Even dragons need connections with more fleeting beings. That is where they draw a kind of vitality. Where they renew themselves.

But separation… the death of those they live alongside, who have supported them… takes its toll. And eventually causes them to stagnate. Or to run wild.

Our clan tends to this. We lighten the load. We offer succour. And we see the same pattern among humans. It is a warning.

A long life and great power demand balance. Responsibility. This ties in with what the three sacred beasts embody.

That is why Johto has entrusted us with the final Gym. Not for excellence in strength. But for harmony. For respect for life and nature. A reflection of what the tradition of Johto still strives to preserve.”

He paused.

“We do not glorify brute power. We uphold simpler virtues. Love. Friendship. Almost dogmatic. Yet undiminished by the passage of time.”

Gold/Richter replied in a low voice:

“Yes… indeed.”

The leader looked at him sidelong.

“You’re not objecting. But you don’t quite believe it.”

Gold/Richter hesitated. His fear of appearing disrespectful was plain to see.

“It’s not that I don’t believe it. It’s just that… in this day and age, we can no longer use them so simply. So naively.

I appreciate them. But they’ve become easy to exploit. Especially by those with evil intentions. Many have paid the price.

We need to be more vigilant. Even Lance… hasn’t entirely escaped it. He nearly lost his way in Kanto. That apprehension… hasn’t left me.”

The chief looked at him more closely.

“Do you know Lance?”

He searched his memory for a moment.

“So…” said the chief. “It was you he was talking about.”

He asked nothing more. Gold/Richter continued, his voice more tense, almost without emphasis:

“Yes. I saw how evil could even use friendship. And love. Against us.

That fear drove me to leave. To check… what, in the tradition, still holds true today.

I belong to a rather conventional generation. But as far as the traditional circles are concerned… I don’t really deserve that name. I’m not quite sure where I stand anymore.

There is a need to adapt. But by adapting, I risk betraying. I don’t really know what to do. Must tradition remain true to itself… or is it merely an identity?”

His gaze had almost frozen, as if under a vague inner pressure.

Outside, Clair had arrived. She did not come in. She was listening from the doorway, without showing herself. The chief had noticed her. He chose not to let on.

He then asked a question that seemed out of place:

“A weak Pokémon. A strong Pokémon. Which do you favour?”

Gold/Richter, taken aback, replied almost on instinct, without thinking:

“Powerful Pokémon. Weak Pokémon. That sort of thinking is for the simple-minded. The world is beautiful… not just because of power.”

The leader smiled ever so slightly.

“There you go. You understand.”

Gold/Richter then realised that the question had been nothing more than a deliberate ploy.

The leader continued, in a more serious tone:

“Your concern is nothing new. Many in positions like mine share it too. I do not believe that tradition should become set in stone. Nor should it remain a mere identity.

Yet we are constrained. By the structure. By the norms. Sometimes even prevented from saying so clearly.

That a young person dares to voice it… brings us relief. Truly."

Gold/Richter replied, almost in spite of himself:

"But young people aren't always right… are they?"

The chief nodded.

'True. But some bring a breath of fresh air. A raw, undaunted spirit. Not always clear-headed. Yet they're willing to take action where others remain silent. That in itself is a form of progress.

That's how a tradition stays alive. How it renews itself. How it modernises… isn't it?"

He left the sentence unfinished, yet firm.

Gold/Richter remained silent. Not all the subtexts were immediately apparent to him. He said nothing in reply.

End of scene

Scene – Young people's confidence in their intelligence

Monastery, Dragon's Den

The silence that followed was brief.

The leader did not turn his head. His voice rose, calm, addressed to the space around him rather than to any one person.

"So you can calm down now, Clair."

Gold/Richter looked up. He instinctively scanned the room, taken aback. Clair was standing near the entrance, still half in shadow. She hadn't expected to be called out. A slight flicker crossed her face — not shame, merely the embarrassment of having been noticed. She took a step forward and emerged from her hiding place.

The chief continued without looking at her.

"Your caution is not merely a figment of your imagination. But what you suspect does not lie in this young man's integrity."

Clair nodded slightly.

"I see…"

Her reply was measured, almost reluctant. A residual resistance lingered within her, a reluctance she made no attempt to conceal entirely.

The chief placed his hands flat on his knees.

“I’ve checked most of them for you. It’s not worth refusing him the badge. As for the rest… I trust your judgement. You can sort them out yourself and manage just fine. It’s worth you having a chat with this young man.”

Her tone was neutral. Neither patronising nor urgent. Merely a statement of fact, and trust granted without fanfare.

Clair understood. He was not forcing her; he was leaving her with full responsibility for what remained to be checked.

She straightened up with her usual rigour, then turned her eyes towards Gold/Richter. Her gaze was more formal than hostile, but the hostility hadn’t disappeared. It was merely contained.

“You. This way.”

She set off without delay. Gold/Richter followed her, his reluctance visible only in the slight stiffness of his shoulders.

Behind them, the chief remained motionless. A very faint smile appeared at the corner of his lips — vague, inscrutable. Wise, strategic, benevolent, calculating… Impossible to tell.

End of scene

Scene – The Obligation of the 8th Gym

Outside the monastery, the wind was drier. The rocks still held the coolness of the shade. Clair stopped at a reasonable distance from the entrance, where she could no longer be heard from inside. She crossed her arms, then uncrossed them almost immediately.

BGM ‘Vampire Messiah’ 00:46–01:17

‘You followed my injunction. And you passed the test.’

She paused for a moment.

“For someone who doesn’t really go to great lengths for the badge… that’s a a rather peculiar remanence.”

Gold/Richter made no attempt to justify himself.

“I got what I was after. That’s enough for me.”

Clair regarded him askance.

“Challenging the gyms… is that just a way of gathering intelligence for you? A series of trials?”

“On behalf of others, too.”

He hesitated.

“I haven’t always won. Not against the Gyms, nor against every Trainer. This… persistence in victory… I don’t really understand it.”

The remark was clumsy. Clair sensed it. Something inside her tensed slightly, then she pushed the feeling aside.

“I’m proud of who I am. But I also know how to admit defeat. Otherwise, I’d never have been entrusted with this task.”

She lowered her eyes for a moment.

“My refusal just now…” she said. “It wasn’t an obsession with winning. It was your performance.”

Gold/Richter did not reply. A faint unease began to well up inside him, still vague, with no specific cause.

Clair continued, more slowly:

“You defeated me fair and square. But what struck me most… is why someone can be So detached. So detached. Even though he’s brilliant. Even the boss acknowledged it. I can’t quite make sense of it.”

Gold/Richter opened his mouth slightly, without really forming any words. His eyes betrayed a subtle bewilderment. He didn’t entirely recognise himself in what she was describing, and yet he didn’t know how to dispute it.

Clair continued, her voice a little lower, almost sullen:

“It matters to me. Because the badge I hold… allows you to command all the Pokémon you own to obey unconditionally. It’s not something to be taken lightly. If it were to fall into the wrong hands, the consequences would be… immeasurable.”

She paused.

“Especially after the Kanto *Gym Leader* scandal. Since then, we’ve become more conscientious. It’s no longer a matter of personal vanity.”

Gold/Richter felt something tighten inside him. A vague sense of shame, a guilt without clear contours, as if she had touched upon something he preferred to keep in the background. His shoulders drooped ever so slightly. He did not look away, but he did not hold her gaze quite so firmly either.

At last he spoke, his voice muffled:

The Gym Leader’s spectre swept through Kanto; it nearly engulfed Johto…

BGM ‘EP01 S02 10:00–10:21’

Clair looked up sharply.

“Are you referring to the raid on the Radio Tower? Why… as if you had witnessed it yourself?”

Gold/Richter lowered his head. He no longer dared to look her straight in the eye. The strain of continuing the conversation suddenly felt too much for him. A clearer sense of guilt, still taking shape, was tightening around his chest.

Clair stared at him, barely blinking. She could not find the answer. She could not even quite grasp the question anymore.

End of scene

Scene – The Stature of the Badges

Outside the monastery, the wind had picked up slightly. Clair stood with her gloves clasped in front of her. Her face, usually so composed, betrayed a vague sadness, as if she had finally come to terms with what she had just heard and no longer knew how to respond.

Gold/Richter, for his part, seemed slightly numb. He'd talked too much. A subtle lethargy weighed on his shoulders.

Clair spoke first, without looking at him straight away.

'…Why didn't you say you'd been sent by Professor Elm? That it was you who'd… saved Johto?'

BGM "EP07 S01 05:36–08:06"

Gold/Richter replied quietly.

"Staying incognito. It's a working code. Since my predecessor."

He added, even more quietly:

"I won. But not on my own. And not honourably."

Clair took a deep breath.

"I would have liked to intervene," she said. "Out of duty. But my brother had asked me to stay. He took the hit for me."

She clenched her fingers slightly inside her gloves.

"I don't accept that it should be up to teenagers to bear this."

"Neither do I."

A silence.

Clair finally turned her eyes towards him.

"Was that what your coldness was all about…? Or another trauma?"

Gold/Richter made no attempt to clarify.

"Yes."

"What terrified you? Their strength…?"

He shook his head.

"No. They weren't particularly strong."

He paused. Then:

"It was… just how clearly you could sense their presence."

Clair's eyelashes barely fluttered.

Gold/Richter continued, his voice more subdued, almost halting.

‘When we discovered Giovanni’s identity… we were surprised that such a prominent man had been able to remain amongst us, in public, right from the start.

But the executives… the very epitome of vulgarity, cruelty and subterfuge.

And him.

I’d heard the name. Then, one day, he stood before me.”

A very clear, almost clinical flash: a white, upright figure, with dry, bureaucratic glances that sought neither to impress nor to threaten. Merely to observe.

‘It was nothing but a white spectre,’ he said. ‘Atrocious. Relentless.’

He continued:

‘Unrealistic. Like a work of fiction. All these things… organised by someone with almost no history. Who didn’t really exist in our world.

A cog in the machine. An amorphous regime. Anonymous. Content to remain invisible. Seeking nothing but control.”

He paused for a moment. His breathing had become more laboured:

“In fairy tales, the villains are predictable. Simplified. We’re led to believe they’re easy to understand.

I had not imagined that evil could be so rational. So disciplined. Sometimes more coherent than many of us.

Sometimes… more so than I am.”

He lowered his eyes.

“The most macabre thing… wasn’t that he was inhuman.

He wasn’t devoid of humanity. But we projected too many expectations onto what a human being ought to be. And he… was perhaps more alive than we were.

Or perhaps it was we who were no longer human.”

Clair attempted a defensive, almost mechanical sarcasm:

“So everyone has to fall in line with him?”

“No. But we expect ideology. Grandiloquence. Charisma. He did without them. He was transparent. Selectively. I couldn’t refute much of what he said. I was too vulnerable to it.”

His voice barely faltered. Very faint, almost invisible tears glistened for a moment at the corners of his eyes without actually falling.

‘Everyday evil… intrinsic savagery…’ he said. ‘They lie dormant in everyone. I can no longer deny it.’

Clair frowned.

“So is everyone evil? Even us?”

“No. But it’s part of this world.

And… when I faced them, I sometimes sensed a kinship. Something I didn't want to see."

BGM 'EP03 S01 15:36–16:22'

He clenched his fists:

"There you go. As you've noticed. I ended up being infected. By his coldness. His ruthlessness. His excessive rationality.

I've become… a bit like him."

Another flash, briefer this time: Apollo's precise, fluid movements. His businesslike gaze. Nothing demonic. Just icy efficiency.

Clair remained silent. A look of contrition flitted across her face.

Gold/Richter continued, exhausted:

"I was a naïve child. I wanted to become the strongest to honour those who had gone before me. So that justice might triumph.

Afterwards… I put that dream aside. I no longer have my sights set on the League. Collecting badges like data. Helping the professor. It was a way of keeping myself in check.

Yet I cannot truly escape it.

I won in an… impure way. I had to resort to savagery. But now, when I call upon it… that bestiality returns. Perhaps because reason is merely a tool. Neutral. And if you use it without integrity, animality takes over. Is this my true self…? I no longer know. Even though I've become what I never wanted to be."

He withdrew further into himself.

"Lance expects me to go to the League. Then to Kanto. But… will I really manage it? Is that still what I want? Am I not already losing my way…?"

Clair looked at him for a long time. Then, quite suddenly, a very neutral, almost cold smile appeared.

"At this rate, yes. You'll probably lose your way."

Gold/Richter looked up, taken aback.

BGM "A Third Soul" 00:00–01:48

Clair continued, still stern:

"You're clever. You keep yourself in check. Sometimes too much so. That's perceptive.

Yet the manner in which you pursue power… is somewhat unnerving."

She took out her badge. The metal caught a faint glimmer.

"Know this. In Kanto, the Gym Leaders are more experienced. More powerful. If you go there treating badges as nothing more than data… ours will be nothing more than trophies. And you'll lose your way."

She took his hand and placed the badge in it with an almost ceremonial firmness.

"Badges mean more than that. Each one symbolises a value. A quality. A principle. The price paid.

We often think we've inherited them. Whereas they merely confirm that we've managed to develop what was already dormant within us."

Very brief flashes of memory crossed Gold/Richter's mind:

Violet. The gymnasium, open to the sky. A Pidgeotto alighted on Falkner's shoulder, perched there for a moment, then took flight without being told. Falkner did not hold the bird back. He merely lifted his chin and invited Gold/Richter to follow its flight. It was not an imposition. It was a way of letting him experience it. Freedom there was not infinite: one did not wander aimlessly, nor did one wallow in it. The absolute did not endure. Yet a minimum of it—whether physical or mental—was needed to move forward without suffocating, without freezing up. A commonplace commodity, which one could only reclaim at a high price once it had been lost. The birds desired it just as much, and confined themselves to it. They were content with it. Without greed.

Outside, in broad daylight. Bugsy amongst Scyther, Metapod and Kakuna. Nothing of a gym. The familiar grass, the air already breathed, and yet he was still searching. His curiosity about his surroundings was insatiable. Even a place that seemed familiar still held things to be discovered, if one was willing. The Insects broadened that access. They expanded a horizon one might have thought insignificant.

Cianwood. Beneath the small artificial waterfall, Chuck had settled down. The water fell ceaselessly, rustling. He did not. Serenity. Tranquillity. The contrast instilled physical discipline better than any speech: to adapt to it was already to master it. He did not ask Gold/Richter to reply. He sought neither retort nor glory. Only that the principle be felt.

Olivine, the moment before the throw. Jasmine had shown almost nothing up to that point. A fleeting grace, unique to that threshold, passed. Slenderness, yet so rigorous that it personified an artisanal momentum — steel, not as a weapon, but as a work of art. It was not evident across her entire face. Only in her eyes. In two micro-gestures. And only to those who had already reached a certain level.

Clair did not withdraw her hand straight away.

"I don't know exactly what quality mine represents. But you've acquired it. I believe that.

That is why you felt as though you were fighting alone. You chose to ignore the rest.

Now… do you still believe that?"

Gold/Richter murmured:

"I didn't fight alone… in terms of power?"

"There is no easy answer. But some people did help you. I suppose."

Other, warmer flashes: Morty and the distinction between life and death, Pryce and the wisdom of ice.

A real, almost physical warmth washed over Gold/Richter. He clenched the badge in his palm.

Clair noted his relief.

Then she spoke more quietly, with a newfound gravity:

"You gave up on your dream. You became someone you never wanted to be.

But… for whom did you do it? Is the person you've become better… for them?

If so, then your wait has been rewarded. Even if the price was a heavy one.

Perhaps that was exactly what you wanted to become. Without realising it.

And if that's the case… that's enough."

She paused for a moment.

"Lance… also lost his way, once upon a time. I doubted him. He eventually proved he was right. Thanks to providence, perhaps.

In that respect… you're alike."

Gold/Richter let out a sigh, almost a weary expression of wonder.

"Clair… You're impressive. To see all that. As a young guardian."

A very faint smile, almost imperceptible, flitted across Clair's face.

'I'm not particularly clear-headed. It's my job that forces me to be.

I remain here to catch those who are about to fall.

So long as our clan watches over this eighth Gym… the same tragedy that happened in Kanto will not happen again in Johto.

You can head towards Lance. And towards Kanto. Without worrying about that."

Gold/Richter felt a genuine sense of relief. Fragile, but real. A quiet reward for all the ground they'd covered across Johto.

End of scene

Scene – The Loss of Purpose

Ecruteak

BGM 'EP05 S02 01:20–02:48'

In the winter twilight, the streets of Ecruteak had emptied. The air was dry, almost biting. The streetlamps had only just come on, casting pale circles onto the dark cobblestones.

Silver walked without any particular direction. His steps followed a meandering path, winding from one alleyway to the next, as if he were searching for something he already knew he could no longer find. The purpose that had sustained him until now had dissolved. All that remained was a void.

An image sprang to mind without warning.

The interior of the Radio Tower. Athena standing before him. Murkrow. His Feraligatr stepping forward. Then, in the shadows, a fluid movement. A ball thrown with clinical precision. It landed right next to Feraligatr. Golbat appeared, already screeching. Screech. Before Silver had even fully grasped what was happening, his Pokémon had been hit. Murkrow lunged forward. A piercing, relentless caw that left no room for a counterattack.

Silver blinked. The image faded as abruptly as it had appeared. He stood motionless for a moment, his face set in a grim expression of silent revulsion.

Then he resumed his walk.

As he rounded a corner, the municipal theatre came into view. Its steps were dimly lit. He approached it without really meaning to, and pushed open the door.

Inside, the Kimono Girls were already standing there. Their gazes fell upon him. Neutral. Almost polar. Yet a subtle melancholy lingered in them, as if they recognised a state of bewilderment from which there was no longer any visible way out.

Silver halted. He did not yet know what lay in store for him.

End of scene

Scene – The Caustic Concession in the Past

Elm's laboratory

Elm's laboratory was larger than one might have expected. Specimens occupied clearly demarcated spaces, with obvious care taken not to cram them together. Daylight streamed in through tall windows and fell softly onto the workbenches.

Gold/Richter and Chris/Maria placed their Pokédexes on the main table.

BGM "EP03 S01 16:54–17:29"

"We've completed your request," said Gold/Richter. "And I've collected all the badges, as agreed, Professor."

Chris/Maria added, standing a little to one side:

"Let us hope… we have not squandered our budget too greatly."

Elm leafed through the files without looking up straight away. He spoke obliquely, almost surreptitiously.

"No. On the contrary. Your use of the grant has been more productive than we expected. Even with a few setbacks."

Gold/Richter lowered his voice slightly.

"Without any additional grant… or funding… we won't be able to explore elsewhere. We'll just have to stay here. Carry on with our studies. Go back to being… ordinary people."

Elm sat up straight. He rummaged through the papers and pulled out a letter.

'You wouldn't rule out broadening your horizons even further… if you were to secure another scholarship?'

Chris/Maria frowned.

"What do you mean…?"

Elm unfolded the letter.

“Lance is summoning you to the League. If your performance is deemed ideal, the League will provide a scholarship for a programme… in Kanto. This offer also applies to Chris/Maria.”

The word ‘Kanto’ hung in the air. The two teenagers did not reply straight away. A long, almost agonising thought flashed across their eyes.

Gold/Richter finally said:

“I’m not in a position to answer that… really.”

‘Neither am I,’ whispered Chris/Maria.

They left the offer hanging in the air, tangible, despite their reluctance.

Elm put the letter down.

“No pressure.”

An awkward silence fell.

Gold/Richter continued, minimising any air of ostentation as much as possible:

“Just by chance… Professor. Why did you endorse my application? Simply… because my results set me apart?”

Elm shook his head.

“No.”

BGM “EP01 S01 14:37–16:34”

Gold/Richter was visibly surprised.

“Weren’t my results… impressive?”

“Not in every area,” said Elm. “But overall, your performance was excellent. Perhaps even too good for your age.”

He paused.

“Your reports are professional. Meticulous. Rigorous. Well-written. Highly constructive for research purposes. But adults… sometimes feel guilty when reading them.”

Gold/Richter’s face paled slightly. Chris/Maria let slip, in a low voice:

“There you go… the bureaucratic symptoms.”

She was not disappointed. Just relieved to have said something.

Elm continued, more slowly:

“You should know that… seeing children’s lives changed so drastically, sometimes compromised… it wasn’t easy. Simply because of a Pokédex. Seeing them part from those dear to them. Adapting to all this… futility.”

He lowered his eyes for a moment.

“I would have liked to reject your applications. So that you wouldn’t suffer any more. Even if that would have frustrated you… at least it would have relieved you of some of your distress.”

A vague sense of despondency washed over the two teenagers.

Chris/Maria asked, almost in spite of herself:

“So… why were we chosen, then…?”

Elm looked up at Gold/Richter.

“Because Gold/Richter was the most sincere towards Red.”

The two teenagers’ eyes widened.

“The other candidates were, on the whole, applying to become as strong as Red,” said Elm. “Or stronger. Gold/Richter was the only one who didn’t care about that. He treated Red… almost like family. He wasn’t looking to take centre stage. He just wanted to share the burden. So as not to drag the others into it.

I thought that resolve… might make all the difference.”

He added, in a quieter voice:

“I expected the road ahead to be tough for you. But you devoted yourself to your goal with such steadfastness… that I couldn’t help but help you make it a reality.”

A silence.

Then Elm continued, almost as an aside:

“That’s why… the Silver case still worries me from time to time. I did it for a teenager who could have been… an insult. A threat to you.”

Gold/Richter replied without hostility:

“His behaviour wasn’t out of the ordinary. And Totodile has evolved into a Feraligatr.”

Elm looked up sharply.

“What? Is he all right?”

“Yes. Generally speaking,” said Gold/Richter.

A subtle look of relief crossed the professor’s face. He leafed through the files again, then pulled out another letter.

“By the way… something happened to him in Ecruteak City.”

“Did he get into any trouble…?”

“Not really. Just a minor incident.”

He handed over the document:

“Here is a summons. From the Kimono Girls. You might be eligible for a scholarship for the programme in Kanto…”

Gold/Richter took the letter, surprised.

“What a coincidence…?”

“No idea. But according to the information… it’s the Legendary Pokémon who are summoning you.”

Gold/Richter fell silent for a moment. Surprise washed over him, and it spread to Chris/Maria.

Elm handed him the summons:

‘I assume you’re more interested in it than I am.’

Gold/Richter did not reply; he was already drifting into deeper thought.

Outside the laboratory, the daylight was brighter. Gold/Richter was absent-mindedly checking the preparations for a possible trip to Ecruteak. He showed no sign of haste.

He noticed that Chris/Maria was still following him.

BGM “EP04 S02 02:30–03:45” 00:29–the end

“You don’t have to force yourself to come with me,” he said. “It’s quite a long way.”

Chris/Maria shook her head slightly. Her tone was more matter-of-fact than usual, almost devoid of sarcasm.

‘It’s out of cultural interest. More than that.

And besides… you’ll need someone close to you who shares a common interest. Won’t you?”

Gold/Richter looked at her for a moment. Then he agreed, without much fanfare. A stern, almost minimal smile appeared on his face.

End of scene

Scene – Innocent and Accusing Glances

Municipal Theatre, Ecruteak

BGM: ‘Powerful Predatory Deadly’ 02:22–the rest

The air inside the municipal theatre was thicker than outside. A subtle pressure weighed on his lungs. Silver stood there, his shoulders slightly hunched. Defeat was already a foregone conclusion. Umbreon and Espeon still stood on the wooden floor, motionless.

BGM: ‘Powerful Predatory Deadly’ 02:35–

The Kimono Girls said nothing. Their gazes had frozen—neutral, almost cold, yet tinged with a restrained melancholy. They showed neither severity nor indifference. Only a sense of caution, as if they knew that one word too many, or one gesture too sharp, might risk aggravating something already fragile. They themselves did not seem entirely sure of the right balance.

Silver saw this. He recognised the absence of hostility. The guilt, however, came from elsewhere.

He looked away towards the two Pokémon.

BGM: ‘Powerful Predatory Deadly’ 02:58–

Umbreon and Espeon were looking at him. There was something surprisingly innocent, almost childlike, about their eyes. Even Umbreon, usually more sombre, seemed devoid of any malice. Their demeanour was calm, open, and seemingly defenceless.

Then, ever so slightly, those gazes hardened.

It was not an accusation. Yet Silver, who knew the conditions for their evolution — trust, prolonged intimacy, a patient bond — took them as such. A paradoxical, unwitting indictment. Through them, he glimpsed what he lacked, what he had always been reluctant to embrace, what he had failed to cultivate.

He had only himself to blame.

BGM: 'Powerful Predatory Deadly' 03:12–

A sudden sense of disarray gripped him. He turned on his heel and strode out, almost as if fleeing.

Behind him, one of the Kimono Girls let out a barely audible sigh. A sigh of helplessness, or of reaching her limit.

BGM: 'Powerful Predatory Deadly' 03:24–

Umbreon and Espeon remained on the floor for a moment longer. Their innocent eyes did not blink.

End of scene

Scene – The Revision of Death

Ecruteak

An early darkness had fallen over Ecruteak on that winter's evening. Near an ancient building of stone and dark wood, intended for discreet gatherings, the air smelled of dry cold and wood smoke. Further away, in an inner courtyard, several Kimono Girls were still dancing. One could hear the steady rustling of their sleeves, the soft sound of footsteps on the floorboards, and their collective, almost synchronised breathing. They were not preparing to welcome anyone.

Gold/Richter, Chris/Maria, Morty and Eusine stood a little apart from the others. Eusine was quieter than usual, his gaze fixed on the frozen ground.

Gold/Richter bowed slightly.

"Thank you for your courtesy, Morty. For sending Mr Eusine to help us…"

Morty did not reply straight away. For a moment he seemed not to grasp what was being said, then he understood.

"…I did indeed pray for you earlier. But he acted of his own accord. The credit is his."

His voice was matter-of-fact. Eusine did not speak up, although he had clearly heard. The main topic did not yet call for his input.

Chris/Maria hesitated. We could see her brief fear of being rude, then she made up her mind.

"I'm sorry, Morty. You said that death was a divine gift. But… could it be… a rehearsal…?"

BGM “EP07S01 17:36–19:00”

The unspoken mention of Athena hung heavy behind the question. Chris/Maria seemed both dismayed and desperate for an answer.

Morty looked at her for a moment. He sensed her frustration, though he didn’t know the exact reasons behind it. He didn’t stop her.

“I can’t escape that question either,” he said. “But I approach it from a different angle.”

His voice changed slightly. Slower. More stern.

‘I said that death, and imperfections, urge us to grow. Yes. One key reason is this: we are not made up solely of ourselves. We are also made up of others. We all depend on one another. Human beings are not merely their own selves. They are also anchors, points of reference. What they have made us become. What they have enriched within us.

When they leave this world, those parts of us begin to crumble. They risk falling into oblivion. We are deprived of them. We become more vulnerable. It can be overcome… but not without a struggle. Most people are not capable of it.

So death is not merely a driving force. It is also… a deliverance from a distress that might otherwise become eternal.”

Gold/Richter spoke in a low voice.

“Is that the price of longevity…? How do dragons cope…?”

Morty nodded.

“Yes. Immortality, or even excessive longevity, leads to accumulated grief. That is why immortals usually look to the past rather than the future. It is possible to transcend this limit… but it comes at a cost. And it is painful.”

Chris/Maria continued, even more hesitantly:

“But… if the deceased, or the martyrs, are reduced to mere symbols… does that also affect… memory…?”

BGM: “EP01S02 12:00–13:54”

Morty did not look away.

“The problem does not lie in the symbols. It lies in memory.

Memories are shaped to suit human convenience. They are often toxic. Selective. Illusory. They can be altered, falsified, softened, manipulated… and sometimes exploited.

Their stories sometimes become… unrecognisable. They no longer reflect who the deceased really were.

We transform loss into a comforting narrative. Into a symbol. Into a justification.

It is a danger of the imagination. Of projection. And we no longer truly respect them. We then live in our own illusion.”

A silence.

Eusine took a step forward. When she spoke, her voice was cold, almost dreary.

‘I argue… that to this day, so many cultures, so many civilisations… despite their antiquity… remain so childish. Immature. Irrational.

Their outward appearances are ancient and sophisticated. But in truth, they are rudimentary. They surrender to their comforts. To their narratives. To their fictions. To their dreamlike fantasies.

Instead of facing reality. Instead of truly growing up. They are constantly escaping. They prefer to remain children… forever.”

Morty did not take the remark as showing off, nor as grandstanding, nor as an exaggeration. One could even see, on his face, something like a subtle sense of relief. Eusine had just put into words what he himself had not wanted to take any further.

Gold/Richter spoke after a moment.

“Indeed. I’m glad… that our culture isn’t quite like that. It’s rather vibrant, I hope…”

Morty looked out towards the courtyard where the Kimono Girls were still dancing. The rustling of the fabric reached them more clearly for a moment.

‘…Yes. Thus, my clan takes it upon itself to maintain harmony, a sense of equivalence with the otherworld. Without vassalage. Without reverential fear. Without condescension. Only with lucidity. Modesty. Serenity in the face of death.

Even in my own time, I must frequently revisit this judgement. Examine the deceased impartially. Acknowledge their tangible achievements… and their faults. This is not blasphemy. It is deference.

The same applies to the living. Or to anything at all.

At this rate, one allows oneself to accept one’s imperfections and one’s finitude… and to truly grow.”

He sighed. A sigh that seemed to channel some of the gloom, without seeking to dispel it entirely.

“Otherwise… we’d be deceiving ourselves. We’d learn nothing. And death would indeed be a repetition… rather than a gift.”

He entrusted these final thoughts to the night air, without expecting a reply. Around him, the others remained silent, in an almost identical frame of mind.

End of scene

Scene – Restoring a dignified life and bringing the deceased back to life

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Background music: ‘Being Dracula’s Son’

The dance had already begun.

The Kimono Girls moved slowly. Their fans opened and closed unhurriedly. Every movement seemed to hold something back, as if refusing to become too light. The light from the lanterns barely grazed their sleeves. In the darkness surrounding the courtyard, a very faint glow clung to the edges of the fabric.

No one was really speaking. You could hear the steady rustling of the silks and, at times, the cold wind sweeping through the city.

Gold/Richter had been watching for a while. Then, in a low voice:

‘Tell me, please. Why are you dancing?’

Sayo did not reply straight away. She let her fan make one final sweep. Her smile was gentle, but it did not reach her eyes.

“Because even if there is no longer any discernment left… we still have gratitude. And memory.”

She twirled the fan slightly between her fingers.

“We put them into dance. Into painting. Not to freeze them in time. So that those who come after us may feel them… even before they understand them.”

A silence settled over the room. Even the movements of the other Kimono Girls seemed to slow for a moment.

Gold/Richter lowered his eyes slightly.

“Sorry about Silver’s mess… and that you had to be less graceful.”

Sayo did not deny it. She simply looked towards Umbreon and Espeon, standing motionless a little way off.

“That boy is seeking power. Words would have made no difference.”

She paused.

“So we showed him in another way. With those who evolve through time… and through bonds. It was brutal. But sometimes clearer.”

Gold/Richter remained silent.

“He isn’t really like that. Something is holding him back.”

Sayo tilted her head slightly.

“We were afraid of offending him. Or of doing the wrong thing. Everyone carries their own burden. One day, we’ll have to pick ourselves up.”
Chris/Maria spoke after a moment, in a low voice:

“Silver’s problem… is it just his confidence? His love for his Pokémon?”

Sayo did not answer straight away. She looked at Umbreon, then at Espeon, both still motionless.

“No.”

She paused.

“The bond with a Pokémon doesn’t come solely from the affection we feel for them. It comes from somewhere deeper. From the way we relate to others. From what we are — or aren’t — able to tolerate in someone else.”

Her gaze never left the two dark figures.

“When something is already broken in our relationship with others… the bond with them suffers as a result. Even if we love them. Especially if we love them,” said Sayo.

Chris/Maria spoke in a very low voice:

“Was it the sacred Pokémon who asked you to do this…? For something so… ordinary?”

Sayo turned to her with a calm, almost sad look.

“Must we wait for the end of the world before they deign to take notice?”

She let the question hang. Then, in an even quieter voice:

“We refuse to accept major disasters. But the small rot of everyday life… we let them slide without saying a word.”

Chris/Maria didn’t reply. Her fingers clenched the hem of her sleeve.

Gold/Richter spoke again after a moment, almost reluctantly:

“He came to Johto for Team Rocket. He stays calm… except with them. Especially when it came to Giovanni.”

He hesitated.

“His motive… I think it’s because of family ties.”

He said no more. There was no need. A quiet sadness swept through the group.

Sayo spoke first, very quietly:

“Yet another curse… from Kanto.”

Gold/Richter barely looked up.

“Do sons really inherit their fathers’ sins…?”

Sayo shook her head slightly.

“No. But without Professor Elm’s intervention… even the most level-headed would have had no reason to tolerate it. He acted in time.”

The silence that followed was longer. The dancing continued further away, as if it had never been interrupted.

Gold/Richter finally asked:

“Why did Ho-Oh and Lugia entrust me with this…? To go to Kanto. To find Red.”

He paused.

“If they can bring back the legendary Pokémon… why not him?”

Sayo’s lips remained sealed for a moment. When she spoke, her voice had lost almost all its pitch.

“Because making a life worthwhile… with all its burdens, its joys, its ties… is no easier than bringing back the dead.”

BGM ‘Dido’s Lament’ 00:32–

Gold/Richter felt the words take hold. He found himself remembering the moment when he had almost given in to Apollo. His hand clenched slightly.

Sayo continued, without straining:

'A life of dignity is something you cultivate. Over a long time. Not with a single gesture. So much so that they have left us this tradition. Not out of blind kindness. Because they know just how fragile it all is.'

Gold/Richter spoke almost to himself:

"I nearly lost to them… even though I still had strength left. Was that the case…?"

"Reason is essential. But it cannot stand on its own," said Sayo simply. "Something else is needed. That which tradition, spirituality and bonds can still sustain. Otherwise, it breaks."

He looked at her.

"You didn't have the answer. You were waiting."

Sayo nodded.

"We had an idea. But we preferred it to be you who came to terms with it."

Gold/Richter realised, a little too late, that he had misread their reserve.

Sayo added, more quietly:

'What Oak and Fuji are doing. What Karin is doing. What Morty and Eusine are trying to do. What you stood up to Team Rocket. It's not a betrayal. It's another way of staying true.'

Gold/Richter tried again:

"Why me…? I'm not cut out for this. And all this talk of the chosen ones…"

Sayo smiled. A clear-eyed smile, without irony.

"It's no fault of yours to be called a hero, a paladin."

BGM: 'Source of Your Fury'

She paused.

"The real problem is whether we choose to bear the burden alongside them. Or whether we leave them to their own devices."

Gold/Richter lowered his voice.

"I'm no longer trying to be the strongest. I've let go of some of that. But I don't feel any lighter. Heavier, actually."

Chris/Maria replied almost immediately, in a curt tone:

"Because you can't run away any more."

The remark struck a chord with him. He didn't reply.

Sayo spoke more slowly:

‘Power numbs. Even in failure, many do not realise their mistake. The other path inflicts more wounds.’

Gold/Richter looked up. A fleeting expression crossed his face.

Sayo concluded, almost as if watching the dance:

“To avoid being crushed, what matters most is often what we do not glorify. Modesty. Perseverance. Integrity. These things transform pain into these precious qualities, without making a spectacle of it. Art can convey them. Without shouting them from the rooftops.”

Gold/Richter murmured:

“That’s why you said science was neutral… but art wasn’t.”

Sayo did not reply straight away. A fan opened slowly behind her.

“Art does not offer quick solutions. But it works on the difference. Between what distorts and what endures. It can conceal. Or reveal. We explore what is good in the company of art. So art is not neutral, nor should it be. And it seems neutral… not because it is a mirage, but because it respects the way we perceive things. Good art accompanies us, rather than dictating to us or imposing itself on us. So that we can still revisit it. Re-examine it. Keep it alive. And preserve the offspring of its reinterpretations. Wherever we come from.”

Gold/Richter remained silent for a long time.

‘…I always feel that exceptions depend on ordinary people. On those who accept us for who we are.’

Sayo replied without beating about the bush:

“They pay too. The debt. A part of it.”

She added, in a lower voice:

“Being ordinary isn’t easy. Too much rigidity is exhausting. Too much generosity is damaging. We need a tradition that still holds… otherwise everything slips away. They don’t just welcome the exceptions. They also keep them from going off the rails.”

Morty, who had remained in the background, spoke in an almost neutral tone:

“When those we love die… that restraint weakens. Often almost irreversibly. Perhaps that’s what death is for, too.”

Eusine continued after him, very quietly:

“People think I’m excessive. Too focused on other things. But merely being tolerated isn’t enough. An exception can become distorted. Turn toxic. Especially where everything pushes you to shut yourself off… like in Kanto. Johto gave me space. I owe it a great deal.”

Gold/Richter took a long time to process this. Then:

‘I accept. The task. To go and fetch Red.’

He hesitated.

‘But they did not speak to me. Ho-Oh. Lugia. Not once.’

Morty gave a very slight smile.

“Were you hoping to see them? Or to catch them?”

His tone was teasing, yet light-hearted.

Gold/Richter shook his head.

“No. It’s too vast. And that distance… it weighs on me.”

Sayo looked at him.

“You’ll meet them. One day. Not now.”

She turned her gaze to the dance that continued in the cold.

“They remain close by. Even if they’re invisible. I often sense them. They know not to reveal themselves too soon. But they’re watching over us. Just like what they left behind. A kind of affection… for all that is human.”

No one spoke any more.

Everyone turned their attention back to the fans. They opened and closed, slowly. The winter wind swept silently across the courtyard.

They made do with the cold.

End of scene

Scene – Ordinary Mercy

Mt. Silver, Winter Dawn

BGM: ‘Making Monsters’ (00:00–00:44)

The snow was falling thick and fast, almost vertically, driven by a wind that had come without warning. It was not yet deadly, just sharp enough to bite into the extremities and slow the blood.

Charizard stood as close as possible to Red, wings half-raised, its short, warm breath blowing against his side. The warmth only penetrated halfway. It was just enough to prevent immediate collapse.

Red had stopped walking. His legs were already sinking up to his knees in the fresh snow. He was barely trembling now. The cold had gone beyond the stage of shivering.

His eyelids were growing heavy.

Then the reverie began without warning.

BGM: ‘Making Monsters’ 00:15–00:44

An elegant, entirely white spectre stood before him in a space devoid of snow or wind. Its features were sharp and matter-of-fact, like those of a man examining a file rather than an adversary. Its gaze did not judge. It observed. Relentless. Inhuman. Spectral.

Red did not recognise the face. Only the sensation of being assessed down to his very last reserve.

The spectre did not speak. There was no need.

When Red returned to the mountain, the weight had not lessened. It had increased. The real snow seemed denser than that in the vision. Charizard let out a low, almost strangled sound and moved even closer, unable to do anything more.

Red remained on his knees.

He knew there were still beings he cared about. He knew that. But that attachment had been worn down too much, stretched too thin. It was no longer enough to carry the rest.

He did not wish to die. He simply no longer knew how to carry on.

His fingers sank into the snow. He closed his eyes.

Background music: 'Powerful Predatory Deadly' (00:44–01:24)

A slender, oblique ray of dawn pierced the gloom.

Charizard was the first to look up. A short, urgent sound. It nudged Red's shoulder gently with his snout, forcing him to look up.

Red obeyed, sceptically.

Above the dark clouds, a large, iridescent bird was flying. Far enough away to remain out of reach. Close enough for every detail of its plumage to be clearly visible. Its path was not directed towards him. It was merely calculated to be seen.

The creature's gaze was neutral. Yet an almost human melancholy lingered in it—an understanding without pathos, a compassion that offered neither promise nor deliverance. Only the acknowledgement that suffering existed.

Red stood motionless.

It was not a divine intervention. It was more modest. More ordinary. As if someone, somewhere below, still cared for him, even without being able to reach him or speak to him.

The threat of snow had not gone away. Nor had the white spectre.

Yet something had shifted.

Red placed one hand on the ground, then the other. He stood up.

Slowly.

End of scene

Scene – The End of Route 22

Route 26, in front of the League's Reception Gate. Winter light.

Background music: 'Wouldn't Understand'

Petals drifted through the cold air. Not many. Just enough to catch the eye. The light was sharp, almost harsh, without being cruel.

Silver stood a little apart, his face barely moving. His eyes were clear, too clear. He was looking somewhere between the ground and the horizon, like someone who had already taken stock of what they'd lost and no longer had the strength to hide it. Gold/Richter had been watching him for a while. Without pity. Only a kind of melancholic respect, and something heavier that he wouldn't name.

Silver spoke first, without looking up.

'You can keep your pity. Or your lecture.'

Gold/Richter did not reply straight away. He let a few seconds pass.

"No," he said at last. "It's just… you haven't crossed the line. Those who put up with you in Johto… Professor Elm in particular… took risks. That's no small thing."

Silver exhaled sharply, almost a joyless laugh.

"I came to Johto to stop Team Rocket. You've taken that away from me. I'll never be able to reach their leader now. My goal… has vanished. And I know why I failed."

Gold/Richter lowered his gaze slightly. He hesitated, then spoke anyway, in a quieter voice.

"Children should not have to bear the burden of their father's mistakes."

Silver turned his head slightly. No anger. Just a brief, restrained surprise. Gold/Richter had not said anything more specific.

"You avoided becoming like him," he continued. "But you didn't know which other path to take. So you followed his. Out of necessity. It's… human. Even when you condemn someone, you don't always escape their logic. It's happened to me too. It cost me dearly. I don't blame you."

Silver remained silent for a long while. Then, in a hoarser voice:

"Three years ago… he abandoned me. Not far from here. On Route 22."

Gold/Richter said nothing. The place suddenly felt heavier.

"You're stronger than you think," he murmured.

"Don't bother," Silver replied at once. "Save your words of comfort."

BGM: "EP01 S02 04:30–05:40"

"It's not comfort. You grew up with your Totodile almost intact. Not perfectly. But you changed something… in the imprecation borne by those who accept a Pokédex. Neither Chris/Maria nor I really knew how to do it. You managed it."

Silver blinked. A brief daze crossed his face.

Gold/Richter continued, more slowly:

"Your journey was not entirely in vain. Had you not come to Johto, I would have found the henchmen harder to handle. You relieved the pressure on me, even without intending to. But had you continued exactly as before… fate would not have spared you. I do not wish that fate upon you."

Silver lowered his gaze.

"Becoming the strongest doesn't mean you can save everything. Perhaps I failed… precisely because I wasn't the strongest."

“Perhaps that is not what you truly seek.”

Silver looked up.

“What do you mean?”

“‘I don’t need weak Pokémon.’ You say that a lot. Yet you’ve never abandoned a single one. I think you already treat them like family. Even if you don’t want to admit it.”

Silver did not reply; something within him had cracked, ever so subtly.

Gold/Richter added, almost as an aside:

“You’d like a simpler life. A more ordinary one. But you’re afraid that dream might prevent you from achieving what really matters. Perhaps you just need to have a little more faith in other paths. I cannot guarantee anything. I, too, have tried to avoid the mistakes of those who came before me. It cost me dearly. But I would like you to find what you are really looking for. And not to become what you do not want to be… or what you think you want to be.”

He was about to leave.

Silver spoke from behind him, in a lower, almost hesitant voice.

BGM: ‘My Sister’ 00:00–00:30

“If the Dragon Master… and one of your predecessors… have already changed what it means to be useful as the strongest… and if you have found other paths… then perhaps I should carry on. To check. Or to find a compromise.”

Gold/Richter paused for a moment. A subtle sense of relief flitted across his face.

Silver added, without looking at him:

“Well then… good luck to the League.”

Gold/Richter turned slightly. He smiled — a firm smile, without pity, without excessive warmth. Just enough to hold on.

Petals continued to drift through the cold air.

End of scene

Scene – Spirituality and the Journey

Final scene. A spacious room at the League. Almost entirely white. Winter light.

BGM: excerpt from ‘My Sister’ (up to 0:30)

Lance’s face filled almost the entire frame. Neutral. Melancholic. A neutrality that came at a cost. His eyes were slightly downcast, like someone still getting used to an absence.

The room was vast, clean, almost abstract. It was hard to tell exactly where one was. Only the bodies present provided a sense of scale.

Lance spoke without looking up.

‘It’s all over…’

A silence.

Then, with his eyes closed:

‘We know how things go round. We know that one day the younger ones will overtake us. But at my age… given what I’ve been through… it’s still hard to take.’

Gold/Richter fell silent for a moment.

“I did my best,” he said at last. “But I didn’t come here to take anything.”

Lance opened his eyes slightly.

Gold/Richter continued, in a lower voice:

“I’ve come to see what you’ve rebuilt. And I’m… satisfied. Proud, even. That it’s you who’s the Champion.”

Lance regarded him for a long time.

“You don’t covet the title?”

“For a teenager, running the League would be too much of a burden. I wouldn’t have come here for that. And I think Red… he must have been relieved to be free of it. He’d be pleased that it’s you. He probably wouldn’t regret leaving.”

Lance did not reply straight away; he seemed to be slowly coming to terms with the role that remained for him.

Karin stepped forward, a wry smile on her face.

“So… if my pupil has defeated you, can I count this victory as partly my own too?”

Lance sighed, almost painfully.

‘Spare me that…’

“I’m just teasing,” she said more softly. “I don’t feel lost. I’ve found a pupil. And I’ve agreed to be a mentor. At least that… I think I was meant to do it.”

She turned slightly towards Gold/Richter. He gave a discreet smile, without a trace of vanity.

Karin continued, more seriously:

“Take this as a thank you. Without what you’ve done… with the League… a lot of things wouldn’t have come to fruition.”

She stopped there. She said no more.

Lance turned his gaze back to Gold/Richter.

“So you’ve made your decision. You’re off to Kanto.”

“Yes. I’m absolutely set on it.”

A silence.

BGM: ‘Divine Bloodlines Reprise’

Then Will appeared almost without anyone noticing him approach, as if he had been there all along.

“Travel broadens the mind,” he said simply. “Some even say that travelling is life itself.”

Gold/Richter lifted his chin slightly. His voice remained calm, but clear.

“So should we travel simply to avoid boredom? To enrich ourselves? To avoid stagnating? Even if it means losing our way a little?”

Will smiled. A broad smile, almost too benevolent given the other man’s reserve.

“That’s why Karin’s old adage has been called into question. In the meantime, it’s my turn to experience something similar.

No. I’m not romanticising travel. Travel without spirituality reveals only the surface. And spirituality without movement quickly becomes dead knowledge. Stepping out or maintaining a certain distance allows us to highlight what we don’t yet know… and what we can still put right.”

Gold/Richter did not reply straight away. The words did not console him. They merely gave him a little more patience.

‘Even to a place like Kanto…?’ he asked at last.

Will nodded slightly.

“Aren’t you being called there? If there is such a thing as divine providence, then you have something to learn there. Even if it certainly won’t be a pleasant journey.”

The words did nothing to lighten the burden. But they made it a little more bearable.

Koga spoke next, without haste.

“Lance has placed me here too, to show that Kanto isn’t entirely closed off. That the traditional spirit still has a place amongst us.

Ninjutsu, poison… these aren’t just stratagems. You don’t win solely through brute force. There’s observation. Patience. A certain wisdom. But for that to remain dignified, you need honour. And a sense of community. I recognise that in you.”

Everyone waited for Bruno.

He remained silent for longer than the others. Then he spoke, slowly, without seeking to make an impression.

“I’m not a man of many words. When someone is worthy of being here… I need only look at them. And see, visualise for myself, what is already within them.”

Gold/Richter looked at them all. Lance. Karin. Will. Koga. Bruno.

Something within him was settling. Not joy. Rather, the feeling that what had been rebuilt was holding firm. That the convergence between the two regions was no longer merely a wish.

He was about to leave. But he was leaving knowing that something, here, had held.

The winter light remained cold and crisp in the white room.

End of episode

Close of episode

Totals

≈ 11,300 words · 32 pp. A4 · read aloud ≈ 75 min.

Pass 1/3 — still open

Clair unique. Dragon’s Den. continued. 01:04–01:51. devotion. Gym Leader. Arbok: a deposit-anchor in the hall. Notes moved here. P1: opening title restored; chef → chief; polarising → polar; boss → chief; pray → ask; rehearsal → repetition; curse (Pokédex) → imprecation; Gold/Richter her → his; Kingdra pronoun still to freeze.

Version notes

2026-09-24 — EN-GB apparatus after P1. Arbok on deposit. Two Lances. Dido’s Lament = external. Traces = address. Author filled. Title: The Living Tradition. Softening paid from Episode 09. White spectre carried into Episode 11.

Open for what follows

Kanto · Red · the white spectre · Silver still on the road.

BGM credits

Pieces: Castlevania: Nocturne (Netflix), Trevor Morris & Trey Toy. Traces: duration only.